

The Patient-Enquiry Checklist

Eight questions that turn “do you have a slot on Saturday?” into a booking request your front desk can confirm in one call, the safety lines every reply should respect, the health-data questions to ask any chat or AI vendor, and a weekly scorecard. Everything here works with the free WhatsApp Business app.

1. Why the first reply matters

Patient messages often arrive in the evening, on Fridays or while your front desk is busy with patients in the waiting room, and a patient who waits may book elsewhere. In Harvard Business Review's study of online sales leads, firms that contacted a lead within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify it as firms that waited longer, and the median response time was 42 hours.

Source: J. Oldroyd, K. McElheran, D. Elkington, “The Short Life of Online Sales Leads”, Harvard Business Review, March 2011 — hbr.org/2011/03/the-short-life-of-online-sales-leads

2. The 8-question intake

Ask these in the first reply. Together they let your receptionist offer the right doctor and slot without a back-and-forth.

#	Ask	Why it matters to the front desk
1	What would you like to book? (check-up & cleaning, pain, braces / aligners, whitening, implants, a child's visit, GP consultation...)	Routes to the right doctor and appointment length.
2	Is this urgent — are you in pain, is there swelling, bleeding or a broken tooth?	Urgent messages go to a person straight away (see section 3).
3	New or existing patient? (existing: file number or registered mobile)	New patients need registration time and forms; existing files can be pulled first.
4	Insurance provider and plan, or self-pay	Lets you check network and pre-approval before the visit instead of at the desk.
5	Which branch, if you have more than one	Avoids booking the wrong location.
6	Preferred days and times (two options)	One confirmation message instead of three.
7	Name, and who the appointment is for (self / child / family member)	Correct file and doctor (e.g. paediatric).
8	Preferred language: English or Arabic	Assign the right staff member for the call-back.

Copy-paste intake message (WhatsApp)

Thank you for contacting [Clinic]! To book you quickly, please send: 1) what you would like to book, 2) if you are in pain or it is urgent, 3) new or existing patient, 4) your insurance provider or self-pay, 5) preferred branch, 6) two days/times that suit you, 7) your name and who the visit is for. Our team will confirm your appointment by [time]. If this is a medical emergency, please call 998 or go to the nearest emergency department.

3. Safety lines for every reply (staff or automated)

- **No diagnosis, no treatment advice.** Replies give information and collect details. Clinical questions go to a clinician.

- **Emergencies are handed to a person at once.** Words like pain, swelling, bleeding, broken, accident — or their Arabic equivalents — should alert staff, and the reply should give the emergency number (998 for ambulance in the UAE) rather than wait for the next slot.
- **Only approved answers.** Prices, packages and insurance lists come from a list the clinic has approved and keeps up to date. If unsure, the reply says a team member will confirm.
- **No slot is confirmed automatically** unless it comes from your real booking system. A human confirms, or the system checks live availability.
- **Marketing content is regulated.** In Dubai, promotional medical content (including social media posts and offers) falls under DHA advertising rules: content needs internal sign-off by the facility and the relevant DHA permit, and misleading or exaggerated claims, and patient images or testimonials without written consent, are not allowed. Keep promotional offers out of routine booking replies unless they have been approved and permitted.

Sources: DHA, Standards for Medical Advertisement Content on Social Media v1.1 (dha.gov.ae/uploads/042022/Standards%20for%20Medical%20Advertisement%20Content%20in%20Social%20Media2022433965.pdf); ABS Partners summary of the 2026 DHA circular (abspartners.ae/dha-standards-for-medical-advertising). Abu Dhabi (DoH) and the Northern Emirates (MOHAP) have their own rules. General information, not legal advice.

4. Health data: five questions to ask any chat or AI vendor

Under UAE Federal Law No. 2 of 2019 on the use of ICT in health fields, Article 13, health information and data related to health services provided in the UAE may not be stored, processed, generated or transferred outside the UAE except in cases set by the health authorities. Ministerial Resolution No. 51 of 2021 lists those exceptions (for example treatment abroad, insurance claims or telemedicine, most with the patient's written consent). Before any tool reads patient messages, ask:

Ask the vendor	A good answer
Where are messages and summaries stored and processed?	Named location and provider, and how that fits the Health Data Law and your regulator's guidance.
What exactly does the assistant collect?	Only booking details (section 2) — no clinical history, images or ID documents in chat.
Who can see the data, and is access logged?	Named clinic staff only; the vendor for support, with access logged.
How long is it kept, and can it be deleted?	A retention period you set; deletion on request.
What happens if it cannot answer?	It hands over to a person and says so to the patient.

Sources: Hogan Lovells, "The UAE's Health Data Law: an important and welcome update permitting certain transfers of health data" (hlc.com); MOHAP legislation page (uaeph1.mohap.gov.ae). Confirm your obligations with your regulator or legal adviser.

5. The weekly scorecard (6 numbers)

Number	How to count it	This week
Booking enquiries	New WhatsApp, Instagram, phone and website enquiries	
Median first-reply time	Middle value of the times from message to first real answer	
Out-of-hours enquiries	Arrived evenings, Fridays or holidays	
Urgent messages	How many, and how fast a person replied	
Appointments booked	From this week's enquiries	
No-shows	Booked but did not attend	

If first-reply time is over an hour, or many enquiries arrive out of hours, that is where automation pays for itself first.

6. See it working for your clinic

Mountain AI builds WhatsApp enquiry assistants for UAE dental and medical clinics. It replies straight away in English or Arabic, asks the intake questions above, flags urgent messages for your team and hands your front desk a booking request to confirm. It only gives answers you approve, never diagnoses, and never confirms a slot on its own. We don't promise a number of bookings: the pilot report shows what actually happened.

Free demo in 24 hours, set up from your clinic's website → **14-day pilot, AED 1,500**, credited in full if you continue → **full setup AED 7,500 + AED 1,250/month**.

Try the clinic demo (fictional clinic): mountainai-ae.com/demo/dental-clinic-assistant.html

Request your free demo: WhatsApp +971 56 777 3366 (send "DEMO") · info@mountainai-ae.com · mountainai-ae.com/clinics.html